The leadership brought into the propulsion group a few more scientists, all PhDs. They included Kanaka Rao, Mathew, M N Nagarajan, B C Pillai, R S Bhute and Agarwal. I was not a PhD, though my Princeton degree kept me in good stead whenever someone sought to put academic background before ground performance, and they thought they could overwhelm me with this new breed of spin doctors.

M N Nagarajan was one of the most argumentative, sometimes impressive, one. Noticing that he had been critical of virtually every idea we discussed in meetings, I suggested that he try out something new.

'What's that?'

'Ion propulsion,' I said. 'Some call it electronic propulsion.'

From my interactions in Vernon, I knew the French were working on electronic propulsion, and by now it was in an advanced stage. Little was known about the technology outside those labs working on it, all we knew was that ions or sub-atomic electric charge was being used for propulsion, which meant a small engine to power a big payload.

I had a gut feeling that electronic propulsion in the long run could be used for interplanetary travel, but I did not foresee its use in satellite launches. To study more, I arranged a visit for Nagarajan and another scientist, S Ramnath (brother of S Chandrasekhar who won the Nobel Prize in 1995), to SEP, France. They stayed in the Vernon facility for a couple of months and returned with some basic lessons.

'Now what,' Nagarajan asked me.

I said it was now his baby, I just opened a door for him. It was for him to decide where to go.

He was not clear where to take his electronic propulsion lessons. And he had a point. Electronic propulsion had no application in any of the projects we were working on. It was like the early years of my fight for a liquid propulsion engine.

Electronic propulsion was, and continues to be, a system of the future. For now, with Nagarajan not showing willingness to toil over a technology of uncertain application, we rested the plan. Many felt it was too far ahead of our times. This, today I feel, was a clear lack of vision, as much as